Circular Retail Environments and the Presentation of Reused Products: A Case Study of ReTuna Recycling Mall, Sweden

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Abstract

Second-hand goods are often seen as worse than new goods, risky or of low quality. This limits reuse as part of a circular economy. This study examines how reused products are presented in ReTuna Återbruksgalleria in Eskilstuna, Sweden, a shopping mall where all shops sell reused goods. The research question is: How do the management and shop staff at ReTuna present reused products through discursive and material practices?

The study is a qualitative single case study. The data consist of interviews with mall management and shop staff, observation from two visits to the mall in 2026, and Instagram posts from ReTuna (63 posts) and from two of its shops, the IKEA second-hand shop (151 posts) and ReBuyke, which sells used bicycles and sports equipment (36 posts). The data were analysed with thematic analysis, using servicescape theory (Bitner, 1992), the view of the shop as a theatre (van Marrewijk & Broos, 2012), and the discursive strategies described by Valor et al. (2022).

The findings show that reused products are presented at two levels. The mall presents the whole place as professional, spacious and good for the environment, while the shops present the products. The IKEA second-hand shop presents used furniture as stylish design and keeps its repair work out of view. ReBuyke presents used bikes as functional and safe to buy through service, a guarantee and a visible workshop. The mall's message that second-hand goods should not be seen as cheap sits beside discounts in both the mall and the shops.

The study adds that a guarantee of function is a way of presenting reused goods that Valor et al.'s strategies do not cover, and that backstage repair work can be shown as a sign of quality. The study shows how reused products are presented, not how customers react to this.

Keywords: circular economy, second-hand retail, reused products, discursive practices, material practices, servicescape, ReTuna

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1 Introduction

1.1 Background of the Study

The global economy still relies mostly on linear production. Resources are taken, made into products and thrown away after use. Even though this linear model has helped economic growth, it uses a lot of natural resources and produces large amounts of waste and greenhouse gas emissions (Geissdoerfer et al., 2017; Kirchherr et al., 2017).

The circular economy is the most discussed alternative to this model. It aims to keep products and materials in use for as long as possible through reuse, repair, refurbishment and recycling (Ellen MacArthur Foundation, 2013; Stahel, 2016). Even though the circular economy gets a lot of attention, it is still not widely practiced. Only about 7.2% of the global economy is estimated to be circular, and this share has decreased in recent years (Circle Economy, 2024).

Most research on the circular economy has been done in economics, strategy and engineering, and there are fewer studies on consumption (Vidal-Ayuso et al., 2023). But consumers play an important role in circularity, because it only works if consumers use circular products (Toth-Peter et al., 2025). Many consumers do not like to use second-hand products because they see them as inferior, risky or of low quality (Toth-Peter et al., 2025).

Retailers connect production and consumers, and some have business models for reused products (Hellström & Olsson, 2024). Sellers of second-hand clothes do work to make them accepted by consumers (Valor et al., 2022). This study describes that kind of work with two terms. The first is discursive practices, which means what sellers communicate about reused products, for example when staff tell customers that a bike has been serviced, or in a sign or an Instagram post. The second is material practices, which means what sellers do with the products, for example washing rugs, repairing a bike or arranging furniture like a room.

1.2 Problematization

Second-hand trading is not a new concept. Some people are willing to buy used products, and antiques and older design pieces, for example, are popular. But there is some doubt about other used products. As mentioned above, many people think of them as inferior, risky or of low quality (Toth-Peter et al., 2025). Valor et al. (2022) describe that there is a stigma around second-hand clothing and show that it can be reduced by the work of sellers, the media and consumers.

But there is less knowledge about how this is done in physical shops, where customers can see, touch and test the product, meet the staff and walk through a place that has been arranged for them. Bitner (1992) calls this physical setting the servicescape and argues that it has an impact on how customers and employees behave. Van Marrewijk and Broos (2012) describe a shop as a theatre, where management designs the space, the objects and the roles of the staff to communicate a brand. Their case is a luxury store selling new menswear. This raises the question of whether it works in a similar way in shops that sell used goods.

ReTuna in Eskilstuna is a useful case for this question. It opened in 2015 as a shopping mall that sells reused products, and it is situated next to the town's recycling centre (ReTuna Återbruksgalleria, n.d.). People bring products there that they no longer want to use. The staff sort, repair and clean the items and then sell them in shops that look much like the shops in an ordinary mall. This ordinary look is the result of the work done by ReTuna's management and staff, and that work is what this study examines.

The shops inside ReTuna are run as different businesses. Each shop has its own character and presents its goods in its own way. There are several shops inside the mall, and this study looks closely at two of them. One is the IKEA second-hand shop and the other is the bicycle and sports shop ReBuyke. One belongs to a global brand, and the other is a small independent shop. The mall and these two shops each have their own space and their own Instagram account. This makes it possible to compare how the three present reused products and to identify the similarities and differences. As far as I know, no earlier study has compared a mall and its shops in this way.

1.3 Research Aim

The aim of this study is to explore how reused products are presented as attractive and trustworthy at ReTuna. The study looks at the mall as a whole and at two separate shops inside the mall, the IKEA second-hand shop and ReBuyke. Here, “the mall” refers to ReTuna’s management, the spaces shared by the shops and ReTuna’s own Instagram account, as distinct from the individual shops. The study focuses on material practices, meaning how goods and retail spaces are prepared and arranged, and on discursive practices, meaning how management and staff communicate about reused products, in person, on signs and on Instagram. The mall and the two shops are described separately and then compared.

1.4 Research Question

Research Question:

How do the management and shop staff at ReTuna present reused products through discursive and material practices?

2 Literature review

2.1 The Circular Economy: Concept and Evolution

The circular economy (CE) has been widely discussed over the past two decades. It draws on several schools of thought, including cradle-to-cradle design, the performance economy, industrial ecology and biomimicry (Geissdoerfer et al., 2017). The CE is understood as an alternative to the linear "take-make-dispose" model of production and consumption (Stahel, 2016).

The Ellen MacArthur Foundation (2013) published an influential report that brought circular economy ideas into mainstream discussion. It describes the circular economy as an industrial system that is restorative or regenerative by design. Kirchherr et al. (2017) took a more systematic approach. They collected 114 definitions of the circular economy and found that the concept is most often described as a combination of reduce, reuse and recycle activities, while the need for a wider change of the system is often left out.

Geissdoerfer et al. (2017) define the circular economy as a regenerative system that keeps resource use low and minimizes waste, emissions and energy loss by slowing, closing or narrowing loops of materials and energy. They compare the circular economy with the idea of sustainability and discuss how the two are related.

The CE is often put into practice through strategies that come in an order, from reducing and reusing to recycling and recovering (Kirchherr et al., 2017). The order matters, because reuse and repair keep a product in use for longer than recycling does (Stahel, 2016). Retail is where products go to customers, which makes it one place where reuse can be put into practice.

There is a gap between how the circular economy is discussed and how it works in practice. Part of the explanation lies with consumers. Limited knowledge of the concept and perceived risks around the quality, function and cost of circular products make people buy fewer of them (Vidal-Ayuso et al., 2023).

2.2 Circular Economy in Retail

The retail sector plays an important role in the circular economy, because that is where consumers buy circular products (Toth-Peter et al., 2025). Circular business models in retail include resale, rental and repair, and the most widespread in the fashion industry is resale (Hellström & Olsson, 2024).

Hellström and Olsson (2024) developed and tested a business model for clothing reuse together with partner companies. They found that a focus on the consumer drives this kind of innovation and that logistics services speed it up.

Reverse logistics takes products back from consumers so that they can be repaired and sold again. Gallegos et al. (2024) review research on reverse logistics and describe uncertainty, for example in transport and in handling returns, as one of the issues this research tries to deal with.

Recommerce means reselling previously owned products, and it allows people to meet their needs at a lower price (Arman & Mark-Herbert, 2021).

In most places, handing in unwanted goods and buying second-hand goods happen in different locations. Integrated formats such as ReTuna bring drop-off, repair and resale together in one place. The focus of this study is on how the goods are presented in the mall and its shops, not on the drop-off system itself.

2.3 Consumer Perceptions of Second-Hand and Reused Products

People's attitudes towards second-hand goods affect whether reuse can grow. In some countries, wearing second-hand clothes is seen as a sign of low status and as a practice linked to poverty (Valor et al., 2022).

Valor et al. (2022) studied how the mass market for second-hand clothing became accepted in Spain. They analysed the websites and social media of sellers, media coverage and video blogs. They found that sellers use three kinds of discursive strategy. Decontamination presents the clothes as clean, selected and checked. Aestheticization presents the clothes as attractive

and fashionable, often by copying how new clothes are presented. Valorization shows that using second-hand products has economic and environmental value. The media and consumers repeat and confirm these messages. According to the authors, this work builds the "relational legitimacy" of the market and reduces the stigma.

The physical shop has been studied by Ross et al. (2023). In four studies, they found that disorder in second-hand shops has two opposite effects. It makes consumers feel they might find a hidden treasure, but it also makes them feel that buying is risky, and the risk matters more than the hidden treasure. They also found that shops can reduce this risk for the consumer by offering a return policy or by showing that the seller knows the stock.

Freitas et al. (2025) study children's thrift stores. They look at three things: the objects (the products and the shop), the doings (what suppliers, shop owners and customers do) and the meanings (what people think second hand stands for). They describe how these three work together to change how second-hand goods are seen.

Marinelli et al. (2025) review 171 studies on consumers and sustainable fashion published between 2020 and 2024. They describe five types of consumers and show that psychological, social and contextual factors shape how people engage with sustainable fashion. They also highlight the gap between positive attitudes and actual behavior.

Gilal et al. (2024) review 105 articles on second-hand consumption. The reasons for buying second hand that these articles study include saving money, fashion, the enjoyment of shopping (recreational motives) and nostalgia. One theory used in this research is consumer contamination. It says that people can feel that a product is less clean because someone else has used or touched it.

Things outside the individual consumer also matter. Gonella et al. (2024) note that infrastructure, such as places to hand in and buy used goods, and public policy influence whether people act in circular ways.

2.4 The Physical Retail Environment

Bitner (1992) studied how the physical environment of a service setting affects the behaviour of consumers and employees. She describes this with the servicescape framework, which is presented in Section 2.5.1.

Egan-Wyer et al. (2025) develop a method called “messy customer journey self-mapping” to study second-hand shopping, which goes across several retailers and across physical and digital platforms. In a study with 13 young adults, they identify three tactics that shoppers use to complete a second-hand purchase: creating notifications, showrooming, and seeking trust via reviews. Shoppers combine online and offline contact points, so the physical shop is one part of a longer shopping journey.

2.5 Theoretical framework

This study uses three concepts to analyse how reused products are presented at ReTuna. Servicescape theory (Bitner, 1992) describes the physical environment. The view of the shop as a theatre (van Marrewijk & Broos, 2012) adds the people who work in the place and the brand they perform. Discursive practices (Valor et al., 2022) describe what is said about reused products, and material practices, a term used in this study, describe what is physically done with them.

2.5.1 Servicescape Theory

Bitner (1992) describes three dimensions of the physical setting: ambient conditions (such as lighting, temperature, noise and smell), spatial layout and functionality (how the space is arranged and how well it works), and signs, symbols and artefacts (which communicate meaning and quality). Customers take these as signs of how the firm works and what it offers. Bitner (1992) describes the environment as a form of nonverbal communication.

Later research supports the framework. Wang et al. (2025) combine the results of 80 empirical studies and confirm that the servicescape affects consumer satisfaction. In retail settings, ambient conditions had a larger effect than layout or signs.

In this study, servicescape theory is used to describe the physical setting of the mall and the two shops.

2.5.2 The Dramaturgical Perspective: The Shop as Theatre

The view of the shop as a theatre builds on Goffman's dramaturgical perspective, which describes everyday behaviour with terms from the theatre, for example front stage, backstage, scripts and roles (Goffman, 1959, as cited in van Marrewijk & Broos, 2012). Studies of retail have used these terms to describe how shops are designed as stages where staff perform for customers (van Marrewijk & Broos, 2012). Van Marrewijk and Broos (2012) apply this perspective to Oger, a Dutch menswear store, and study how its management and shop staff build and communicate the brand through the space of the store.

In the store, the front stage is the sales floor, where staff engage with customers with the help of items such as mirrors, tables and coffee cups. Backstage is where management trains the staff and prepares the performance, where customers cannot see it.

To analyse the space, the authors use four categories from Yanow (2006, as cited in van Marrewijk & Broos, 2012): design vocabularies (the shape, size and materials of the building), design gesture (how the building relates to its surroundings), design proxemics (the distances between people, and how space brings them together or keeps them apart) and décor (furnishing, objects on display and what staff wear). The authors extend the third category to "internal design proxemics", meaning how the items and settings inside the store shape the meeting between staff and customers.

Two points from their study of Oger matter for this study. First, they argue that earlier research was done on design and display, but that there are few studies on the role of staff. This study therefore also looks at the role of staff. Second, they identified a gap between what management said and what happened in daily work. Oger's management talked about moving away from a focus on sales, but in daily work, sales were still what counted. This study examines whether what is said and what is done match at ReTuna.

Their study has one clear difference from this one. Oger is a luxury store that sells new clothes, while the shops at ReTuna sell reused products. This study therefore examines how far the theatre perspective fits shops that sell reused products.

2.5.3 Discursive and Material Practices

Discursive practices are what sellers say and show about reused products. The term builds on Valor et al. (2022) and the three discursive strategies described in Section 2.3: decontamination, aestheticization and valorization. Valor et al. (2022) also describe validation, where sellers and media show that many people, or admired people, already buy second-hand.

Material practices are what sellers physically do with the products and the space, such as cleaning, repairing, sorting and displaying. Valor et al. (2022) studied websites, social media and media texts, so their study does not cover this physical work. For this part, the study relies on Bitner (1992), who describes the physical setting, and on van Marrewijk and Broos (2012), who argue that the social and the material sides of a shop should be studied together.

The two kinds of practice can support each other or pull apart. A sign saying that rugs are washed is a discursive practice, and the washing is a material one. The analysis looks at both and at whether they match.

2.5.4 How the Framework Will Be Applied

The three concepts are used for different tasks. Servicescape theory guides the description of each setting: lighting, layout, signs and symbols. The theatre view is used to ask what is shown on the front stage, what is kept or revealed from backstage, and what role the staff play. Discursive and material practices are used to sort the data into what is said, in interviews, on signs and on Instagram, and what is done, and to compare whether the two match. The same steps are applied to the mall, the IKEA second-hand shop and ReBuyke, so that they can be compared.

3 Research Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This study is a qualitative case study. The aim is to describe how reused products are presented at ReTuna, and the material for this is what people say, what places look like and what is posted online. This material consists of words and images, so a qualitative design was chosen. Van Marrewijk and Broos (2012) note that research on consumer culture mainly uses ethnographic and qualitative methods, because the experience and the social side of consumption are hard to capture with experiments or surveys (p. 378). They studied a clothing store through observation, filming and interviews, and this study uses the same kinds of data on a smaller scale.

The study takes an interpretive approach. The material is read for the meanings that management and staff give to reused products, not measured in numbers.

3.2 The Case and Sampling

The case is ReTuna in Eskilstuna, Sweden. ReTuna is not a typical shopping center, because it is a whole mall where the shops mainly sell reused goods, and it stands next to the town's recycling center (ReTuna Återbruksgalleria, n.d.). Flyvbjerg (2006) argues that atypical cases often reveal more information than typical ones, because more actors and more basic mechanisms are at work in them (p. 229). ReTuna is studied here as such a case. He also argues that one can often generalize from a single case, and that "the force of example" is underestimated (p. 228).

Three parts of the case are studied: the mall as a whole, the IKEA second-hand shop and the bicycle and sports shop ReBuyke. Flyvbjerg (2006) describes information-oriented selection, where cases are chosen for the information, they are expected to give. One form of it is maximum variation, where the cases are very different on one dimension, such as size or form of organization (p. 230). The two shops were chosen following this idea: one belongs to a global brand and the other is a small independent business. Both have their own Instagram

account. The choice was also limited by access, because the two shops had to be among those where staff agreed to be interviewed.

The interview participants were chosen because they work with how products are presented at ReTuna: two people from mall management and staff from three shops. How they were contacted is described in Section 3.3.1.

The findings describe ReTuna and these two shops. They are offered as an example, not as a result that holds for all second-hand shops.

3.3 Data Collection

Three kinds of data were collected: interviews, observation and Instagram posts. Table 1 gives an overview.

Table 1

Overview of Data Collection

Data	What it consists of	When
Interviews, mall management	2 interviews in person, notes taken by hand. One manager also answered the questions in writing in Swedish afterwards	Spring 2026
Interviews, shop staff	3 interviews in person (IKEA second-hand shop, ReBuyke, book shop), notes taken by hand	Spring 2026
Observation	The mall, the IKEA second-hand shop and ReBuyke. Photos and two videos of the mall, shop fronts and back areas; field notes taken during the visits	17 March 2026 and early summer 2026
Instagram, ReTuna	63 posts from the mall's account	25 April 2025 to October 2026
Instagram, IKEA second-hand shop	151 posts from the shop's account	31 March 2025 to 8 October 2026
Instagram, ReBuyke	36 posts from the shop's account	30 March 2025 to 3 October 2026

3.3.1 Interviews

Five interviews were carried out in person at ReTuna in spring 2026: two with mall management and three with shop staff from the IKEA second-hand shop, ReBuyke and the book shop. The two managers were reached through earlier contact with ReTuna. For the shop staff, about seven shops in the mall were asked, and staff in three of them agreed to take part. Interviewing both management and shop staff follows van Marrewijk and Broos (2012), who interviewed the founder and management team of the store they studied as well as five shop attendants (pp. 379–380).

Each interview lasted about 20 to 30 minutes and was held in English. The interviews were not recorded. Notes were taken by hand during each interview and written out afterwards. One of the managers also answered the questions in writing in Swedish after the interview. Her answers were translated into English with Google Translate. The interview guides are in Appendix A and Appendix B. The questions asked how products are prepared and displayed and how staff and management talk about them.

Because the interviews were not recorded, the quotations in Chapter 4 come from the notes and may not be the exact words of the participants. The exception is the manager who answered in writing. Her quotations are translations of her own written words.

3.3.2 Observation

The observation was inspired by van Marrewijk and Broos (2012), who studied how a clothing store used its space, its objects and the roles of its shop attendants to communicate its brand (p. 374). Their fieldwork included two months of observation and 17 hours of film (pp. 378, 380). The observation in this study is much smaller. ReTuna was visited on 17 March 2026 and again in early summer 2026.

On the first visit, photographs and two short videos were taken of the mall's shared areas, the shop fronts, the drop-off point, the sorting hall and the workshop. Field notes were taken during both visits about the mall and the shops and were later written up in full. The

description of the inside of the IKEA second-hand shop and ReBuyke is based on the field notes. These notes were checked against the photographs and videos from the visit and against pictures of the shop interiors in the shops' own Instagram posts. Both visits took place before ReBuyke rebuilt its shop in the summer of 2026, so the observation describes the shop before the rebuild. ReBuyke's Instagram posts from after the rebuild show the new shop and were not used to check the observation notes.

The notes and photographs were sorted with four categories for studying space that van Marrewijk and Broos (2012) take from Yanow (2006): design vocabularies, which concern the shape, size and material of a building; design gesture, which concerns how the design fits in with or stands out from its surroundings; design proxemics, which concern the spaces between people that shape how they behave and interact; and decor, which includes furniture, art and photographs as well as dress codes (Yanow, 2006, as cited in van Marrewijk & Broos, 2012, p. 379).

3.3.3 Instagram Posts

Posts were collected from three public Instagram accounts: ReTuna's own account, the account of the IKEA second-hand shop and the account of ReBuyke. For each account, all posts published in the period shown in Table 1, up to early October 2026, were saved as screenshots.

For each post, the date, the first picture and the caption were recorded. Comments from followers were noted where they said something about the products or the shop. The captions are in Swedish. They were copied into Google Translate and translated into English, so some meaning may have been lost.

Only the first picture of each post was analyzed, because it is the picture followers see first in their feed.

3.3.4 Consumer Questionnaire

At an earlier stage of the study, a short questionnaire was answered by ten visitors to ReTuna. The number of answers is small, and most were given with the researcher present. For these reasons the answers are not used as evidence in this study. (see Appendix C)

3.4 Data Analysis

The data were analyzed with thematic analysis, following the six phases described by Braun and Clarke (2006): becoming familiar with the data, generating initial codes, searching for themes, reviewing themes, defining and naming themes, and producing the report.

Braun and Clarke (2006) distinguish between an inductive analysis, which starts from the data, and a theoretical analysis, which starts from the researcher's theoretical interest. This study used the theoretical form. The codes came from the framework in Section 2.5: the three discursive strategies of decontamination, aestheticization and valorization, and validation work (Valor et al., 2022); material practices such as cleaning, repairing and displaying (Section 2.5.3); the dimensions of the servicescape (Bitner, 1992); and front stage and backstage (van Marrewijk & Broos, 2012).

The interview notes, the observation notes and the Instagram posts were coded in this way. The mall, the IKEA second-hand shop and ReBuyke were analysed one at a time and then compared. For the Instagram posts, the number of posts with each theme was also counted. One post can have more than one theme, so the numbers do not add up to the total number of posts.

3.5 Research Quality and Limitations

Several steps were taken to make the study trustworthy. The three kinds of data were compared with each other, so that a point found in one source could be checked in another. The observation notes were checked against the photographs, the videos and the shops' own Instagram pictures. For each Instagram account, all posts in the period were included, so the posts were not chosen to fit the analysis. Material that did not fit the codes, such as critical comments from followers, was also noted. A claim in Chapter 4 is made only when it is supported by a quotation, an observation or a post. Finally, the method is described in detail in this chapter, so that readers can judge how far the findings may apply to other settings.

The study also has limits. It is a single case. Only five people were interviewed, and their answers were written down by hand. The observation of ReBuyke describes the shop before

it was rebuilt in the summer of 2026. The Instagram captions were translated from Swedish with Google Translate, and only the first picture of each post was analyzed. Meetings between staff and customers were not studied systematically, so the study says little about what happens between them. The material was coded and interpreted by one researcher alone, so another researcher might read some of it differently.

3.6 Ethical Considerations

The study followed the principles of informed consent, confidentiality, anonymity and the right to withdraw. Before each interview, participants were told the purpose of the research, how their answers would be used and how their identity would be protected. They gave verbal consent before the interview began and were reminded that taking part was voluntary and that they could withdraw at any time. They are not named and are referred to by their role, for example Manager A or the IKEA employee. No participants were asked to share sensitive personal information, and the study did not involve any vulnerable groups.

The handwritten notes and the completed questionnaires are kept in a secure place that only the researcher can access. They will be deleted once the thesis has been approved and the examination process is complete.

The Instagram accounts are public and belong to organizations. Followers who commented on posts are not named, and neither are staff members who appear in posts. Comments from followers are described in the researcher's own words and are not quoted, so that they cannot be traced back to a person by searching for the text. Photographs that show people's faces are not included in the thesis.

4 Findings

This chapter presents what the interviews, the observation and the Instagram posts show about how reused products are presented at ReTuna. The mall is described first, then the IKEA second-hand shop and then ReBuyke. For each, the physical setting and the material practices come first, followed by what is said about the products. Section 4.4 compares the three, and Section 4.5 sums up. Quotations from the interviews come from the researcher's notes and may not be the participants' exact words. Quotations from the written answers of one manager are translated from Swedish.

4.1 The Mall

4.1.1 The Physical Setting

The outside of the building tells visitors what kind of place this is. A text on the outside wall says "Här blir det gamla det nya" ("Here the old becomes the new"). Bitner (1992) describes such signs as part of the physical setting that communicates with people, here before visitors enter the building. The text suggests that ReTuna is not an ordinary shopping centre, because what is sold inside has been used before.

Inside, the mall is a large and open hall. Manager B said in her written answers that a spacious and professional look is something ReTuna plans on purpose:

> It is important that customers get a feeling that professional people work here; it is important that it looks good and is spacious. Many who visit ReTuna for the first time are impressed especially by how much space there is in the building. (Manager B, written answers)

Manager A also mentioned the smell and light of the building, two of the ambient conditions in Bitner's (1992) servicescape:

> We take care of used items and make it useable again – we clean them and make the good smell rather than the second-hand smell. We have great lighting, business circulation and visual mechanism. (Manager A)

The observation matched this description. The shared areas were light and tidy, with places to sit and a cafe. Manager B described these areas as part of the offer:

> This mall has more area for rest and relax while doing shopping. You can eat in the restaurant and sofa and many sitting areas. Shops are different, display is different, convenient to customers. (Manager B)

In Bitner's (1992) terms, the mall works on its spatial layout and its ambient conditions so that the hall looks like an ordinary shopping center rather than a charity shop. This is a material practice: nothing is said about the products, but the setting shows them in a commercial light.

The drop-off point, where people leave things, they no longer want, is located next to the shops. The sorting and the workshop, where goods are checked and prepared, do not take place inside the shops. Seen through the theatre view of van Marrewijk and Broos (2012), the drop-off point is part of the front stage; while sorting and repair are similar to the backstage, out of the shoppers' way. Other shops in the mall also showed repair work. In the electronics shop, televisions were switched on and staff were repairing items, and the book shop offered space to sit and read. The book shop employee described this as a choice:

> The display and set off like light and space to sit, read and find the books… We provide enough space to leisurely buy the books. No hurry. (Book shop employee)

4.1.2 What the Mall Says

The written answers show a clear division of roles between the mall and the shops:

> Each shop communicates with its customers itself. The communication that ReTuna (that is, Eskilstuna Energi och Miljö) does emphasizes the environmental benefit, and shows the side activities arranged in the premises, the conference rooms, and the breadth of shops. (Manager B, written answers)

ReTuna's Instagram account follows this division. Environmental or circular words appear in about half of the captions. Other posts present events such as clothes swaps and toy swaps, clearance weeks, the conference rooms, new tenants and municipal projects. In August 2026, several posts linked the drop-off point to the shops, showing that what is handed in may later be sold in the mall. In 2026 the account also shared that ReTuna had received the award "Circular Retail of the Year 2026".

In Valor et al.'s (2022) terms, this is mainly valorization: the mall presents reused goods as worth something because they are good for the environment. The award and the description of ReTuna as unique also work as validation, showing that others approve of the concept. The manager added a second kind of value, which concerns quality and price:

> The idea some customers have that everything second-hand MUST be cheap is something we need to get away from. Instead, it is what is of poor quality that can be cheap. (Manager B, written answers)

The manager also described a difference between ReTuna and charity shops, because the shops in the mall are run by private businesses: "this shows in, among other things, the shops' range of products, the quality of the goods, the staff's knowledge, the guarantees that are issued". At the same time, the mall does not control the shops' prices: "all shops set their prices independently".

One post on ReTuna's account needs to be explained. A caption from 7 October 2025 said that one could "reduce your climate anxiety by 50%" by sorting waste and not buying new things. The post was written by a music account and shared on ReTuna's account, and its tone is humorous. It is therefore not treated here as ReTuna's own message.

4.2 The IKEA Second-Hand Shop

4.2.1 The Physical Setting and Material Practices

The IKEA second-hand shop calls itself the world's first IKEA second-hand shop. From the outside, it looks very similar to an ordinary IKEA shop: the shop front had raised platforms of chipboard with spotlights, and the price tags showed the decade each product came from. Inside, the furniture was arranged in room settings, as in an ordinary IKEA store. The IKEA employee described this layout:

> We have different area to display product same like normal IKEA shops – for example living area, apartments, dining area, office place, office chairs, kitchen, and small furniture are separately. (IKEA employee)

In the terms of Yanow (2006, as cited in van Marrewijk & Broos, 2012), the decor and the layout copy the shop's parent brand. The shop does not look like a second-hand shop; it looks like IKEA.

The material work on the products was described in the interview and repeated on Instagram. The employee said: “We don’t do major repair… we do cleaning and wax the product. People can trust and buy the product.” On Instagram, 16 of the 151 posts state that a product has been cleaned, checked or repaired. One text, saying that the rugs have been professionally washed, was repeated in about six posts. Other posts show staff re-covering a sofa.

One practice protects the front stage directly. Posts explain that items in the shop window cannot be taken home on the day they are bought. This keeps the display complete. The window is the most-shown subject on the account (76 of 151 posts), and the shop keeps it complete even if the buyer has to wait to collect the item.

The repair work takes place inside the shop, but in a separate area away from the display, where customers do not see it. Using the theatre view of van Marrewijk and Broos (2012), this area is the backstage: the work that prepares the products is kept out of view, and only the finished furniture is shown on the front stage.

4.2.2 What the Shop Says

The IKEA posts are mainly about how the products look and where they come from. Almost half of the posts (74 of 151) place the products in a season or a home, and 47 tell the design history of a product, for example the decade it was made. One post describes worn furniture as more beautiful because it has been loved. In Valor et al.’s (2022) terms, this is aestheticization: used furniture is presented as attractive, stylish and unique. Texts on the shop’s walls, shown in its posts, say the same thing: “Vi tror på en andra chans” (“We believe in a second chance”) and “Länge leve våra möbler” (“Long live our furniture”).

Decontamination is also present, but less often. The employee said that customers ask about hygiene, and that staff answer by explaining how the products are cleaned: “We talk about these items – they are good clean and wash… customers ask about the hygiene.” On Instagram, the washed rugs and the cleaned products play the same role.

Valorization is used less often. Lower prices or discounts appear in 17 posts, and environmental or circular words in only 9, most of them between late November and mid-December 2025. The employee also used history as a value: “We talk about the history of this

product. Some people like to buy old product." Validation comes mostly from the IKEA name itself, and from posts that present the shop as the first of its kind.

Not all reactions on Instagram were positive. On two posts, one follower commented that the prices were too high. In the field notes, the prices also seemed higher than in a charity shop. The staff described this as value for money: the products are checked, cleaned and of good quality.

4.3 ReBuyke

4.3.1 The Physical Setting and Material Practices

ReBuyke sells used bicycles and sports equipment. During the visits, the entrance was narrow and full of goods, and the shop looked more like a modern sports shop than a second-hand shop. It was busy on both visits. Staff were advising customers and checking or fixing items before selling them, and the stock changed with the season.

The repair work is a central part of the shop. ReBuyke calls itself a "workshop shop" on Instagram, and six posts offer repair, sharpening or adjustment services. The ReBuyke employee described the checking of goods as the basis for selling them:

> New sports items are very expensive, so we sell items for affordable price. And we make sure these items are not broken and people can use it. (ReBuyke employee)

According to the employee, customers could also try bicycles before buying. Seen through the theatre view (van Marrewijk & Broos, 2012), ReBuyke does not hide its backstage. The repair work is shown as part of what the shop offers. One post even offers unrepaired bikes for parts or as projects, so the different conditions of the goods are stated openly.

In the summer of 2026, after the visits, ReBuyke rebuilt its shop, and its later posts show the new interior.

4.3.2 What the Shop Says

ReBuyke's 36 posts are short and practical (see Table 2). The owner often writes as "me". A recycling symbol appears in 27 captions, but environmental words appear in only 2. The most detailed message is about security for the buyer. One post explains why a customer should

buy a bike at ReBuyke: the bikes are serviced, they come with a one-month guarantee, and they can be returned within a week. A similar message is shown on a sign in the shop window.Guarantees or the right to return are mentioned in 9 posts, and lower prices in 6.

This message does not fit neatly into Valor et al.'s (2022) strategies. Decontamination, in their study, is about erasing signs of use, so that clothes appear clean and new. ReBuyke does not hide that its bikes are used. Instead, it reduces the buyer's risk through service, a guarantee and a right of return, and it states the price advantage directly. The price argument is valorization in Valor et al.'s sense. The guarantee, however, works more like a promise about function than a statement about cleanliness.

Table 2 sums up the themes in the Instagram posts of both shops.

Table 2

Themes in the Instagram Posts of the Two Shops

Theme in the post	**IKEA second-hand shop (151 posts)**	**ReBuyke (36 posts)**
Shop window or display shown	76	–
Season or home life (for example Christmas, summer, a cosy home)	74	–
Design history (the decade or the designer of a product)	47	–
Limited stock ("here today, maybe not tomorrow")	24	–
Lower price or discount	17	6
Cleaning, condition or repair stated	16	6
Reuse words ("second chance", "new life")	15	–
Environmental or circular words	9	2
Recycling symbol in the caption	–	27
Guarantee or right to return	–	9
"New pictures" or "taken today"	–	6

Note. One post can have more than one theme. "–" means the theme did not appear or appeared only rarely.

4.4 Comparing the Mall and the Two Shops

Table 3 compares the mall and the two shops.

Table 3

How Reused Products are Presented by the Mall and the Two Shops

	The mall	**IKEA second-hand shop**	**ReBuyke**
Main message	Environmental benefit; a professional, spacious place	Design, style and the IKEA story	Function, price and guarantee
Strongest strategy (Valor et al., 2022)	Valorization (environmental value) and validation	Aestheticization	Valorization (price) and a guarantee
Material practices seen or described	Large, light hall; seating and cafe; drop-off next to the shops	Cleaning, waxing, washing rugs, re-covering; room settings; protected shop window	Checking, servicing and repairing bikes; workshop in view
Backstage	Sorting and workshop areas kept separate from the shops	Repair area inside the shop, but out of customers' view	Repair work shown as part of the shop
Environment in words on Instagram	In about half of the captions	9 of 151 posts	2 of 36 posts (recycling symbol in 27)

The comparison shows a division of work. The mall carries the environmental message, as its management described. The two shops rarely speak about the environment in words, and each presents reused products in its own way: the IKEA shop through design and style, ReBuyke through function, price and a guarantee.

What is said and what is done match in several places. The IKEA shop says that products are cleaned and its staff describe cleaning and waxing them. ReBuyke says that its bikes are serviced and its workshop is visible in the shop. The manager's statement that ReTuna should look professional and spacious matches the observation of the hall.

There are also tensions. The manager said that second-hand goods should not be seen as cheap, and both shops present themselves as offering good quality. Yet both shops also use

lower prices and discounts in their posts, and the mall itself runs clearance weeks. The prices are set by each shop, not by the mall, so the mall cannot fully control how the shops present their prices. At the same time, the mall's own clearance weeks show that discounts are part of the mall's message too.

4.5 Summary of Findings

At ReTuna, reused products are presented at two levels. The mall presents the whole place as professional, spacious and good for the environment, and it leaves the communication about products to the shops. The IKEA second-hand shop presents used furniture mainly as beautiful and stylish, with cleaning described as proof of care, and it keeps its repair work backstage, out of the customers' view. ReBuyke presents used sports equipment as functional and safe to buy, through service, a guarantee and a visible workshop. The shops' material practices mostly match what they say, while the mall's message about quality sits beside discounts in both the mall and the shops. These findings are discussed in Chapter 5.

5 Discussion

This chapter discusses the findings in relation to the research question and the literature in Chapter 2. It looks at where the findings agree with earlier studies, where they differ, and what they add.

5.1 Two Levels of Presentation

The findings show that reused products at ReTuna are presented at two levels. The mall presents the place, and the shops present the products. The management described this division itself: each shop communicates with its own customers, while ReTuna's communication emphasises the environmental benefit. The Instagram accounts follow the same pattern. Environmental words appear in about half of ReTuna's captions, but in only 9 of the IKEA shop's 151 posts and 2 of ReBuyke's 36.

Earlier studies mostly look at one seller or one platform at a time. Valor et al. (2022), for example, studied the websites and social media of second-hand clothing sellers, the media and video bloggers in Spain. At ReTuna, the work of making reused goods acceptable is shared between a mall and many separate shops, and the two levels say different things. This suggests that, in a setting like ReTuna, the environmental message and the selling message can come from different actors. The shops can then speak to other reasons for buying second-hand. Gilal et al. (2024) report studies in which economic, fashion and recreational motives drive second-hand purchases, and the two shops speak mainly to such motives: the IKEA shop to style and design, ReBuyke to price and function.

5.2 An Ordinary Mall on Purpose

At first sight, ReTuna can look like an ordinary shopping centre. The findings suggest that this was done on purpose. The management wanted the building to look professional and spacious, and the hall has the light, seating and cafe of a mainstream mall. In Bitner's (1992) terms, the mall uses ambient conditions and spatial layout to give reused goods the setting of new ones.

It is important because many people have a negative view of second-hand goods. Toth-Peter et al. (2025) mention that many consumers do not like to buy second-hand goods because they see them as inferior, risky and of low quality. Ross et al. (2023) found that disorder in second-hand shops raises perceived risk more than it raises the sense of finding hidden treasure. ReTuna's management makes sure the place is organised and has a lot of space, rather than the crowded look of many second-hand shops. This study did not ask customers what they think about this organised and spacious place, so it cannot say whether it lowers their sense of risk. What it shows is that the management treats the ordinary look of the mall as part of how reused goods are presented.

What makes ReTuna different from an ordinary mall is therefore not mainly how it looks. It is how it is organised: privately run shops in a mall run by Eskilstuna Energi och Miljö, which sets rules for what may be sold, next to a recycling centre and a drop-off point where people leave things that may later be sold in the shops. The facade text, "Here the old becomes the new", is one of the few places where the building itself states this difference.

5.3 Valor et al.'s Strategies Outside Clothing

Valor et al. (2022) described three discursive strategies, decontamination, aestheticization and valorization, and validation work, in the market for second-hand clothing. The findings show that these strategies also appear for furniture and sports equipment, but in different mixes.

The IKEA second-hand shop fits Valor et al.'s aestheticization closely. Its posts present used furniture through design history, seasons and home styling, much as Valor et al. describe sellers who copy the presentation of new goods. The shop also borrows the layout of an ordinary IKEA store. In this case, the brand of the new goods company becomes a resource for presenting its used goods.

ReBuyke does not match Valor et al. exactly. Their study describes decontamination as erasing signs of use so that clothes appear clean and new. ReBuyke does not hide from customers that its bikes are used, but it reduces the customers' risk through service, a one-month guarantee and a one-week right of return. This matches what Ross et al. (2023) found: second-hand

retailers can reduce risk by offering a return policy or by showing that the seller knows the inventory. The findings therefore suggest that, for goods that must work, such as bicycles, a promise that the product works may play the same role as a promise of cleanliness does for clothes. Valor et al.'s strategies, built on clothing, do not name this kind of work, and this is one way in which the present study adds to them.

5.4 Front Stage and Backstage

Van Marrewijk and Broos (2012) found that the management of the Oger store controlled the work of shop attendants backstage, invisible to the consumers (p. 385). At ReTuna, the three units handle the backstage in different ways. The mall keeps its sorting hall and workshop apart from the shops. The IKEA shop repairs products in a separate area inside the shop, out of customers' view, and protects its front stage by not letting customers take items from the window on the day they buy them. ReBuyke, by contrast, shows its repair work as part of the shop and calls itself a workshop shop.

This suggests that the theatre view needs one adjustment for reused goods. In a luxury store selling new clothes, the backstage is hidden so that the performance looks perfect. For reused goods, the backstage work of checking and repairing can itself be a sign of quality. Whether a shop hides it or shows it appears to depend on what the shop sells: the IKEA shop sells a look, and ReBuyke sells something that must work.

5.5 What Is Said and What Is Done

Van Marrewijk and Broos (2012) also identified a gap between what the managers said and what actually happened in the shop every day (p. 385). At ReTuna, what is said and what is done mostly match at the level of each shop. The IKEA shop says that its products are cleaned, and its staff describe cleaning and waxing them. ReBuyke says that its bikes are serviced, and its workshop is visible.

A gap appears between the levels. The management said that second-hand goods should not be seen as cheap, and that only poor quality should be cheap. Yet both shops use discounts in their posts, and the mall itself runs clearance weeks. At the same time, one follower

complained that prices at the IKEA shop were too high, so the prices are not seen as low by everyone. Because the mall does not set the shops' prices, it cannot fully control how the shops present them. The gap is therefore not simply a sign that anyone says one thing and does another. It shows that, in a mall of independent shops, no single actor controls the whole presentation of reused goods.

5.6 Summary of Discussion

The discussion has shown four points. First, reused products at ReTuna are presented at two levels, with the environmental message at the mall level and selling messages at the shop level. Second, the ordinary look of the mall is a deliberate choice, while ReTuna differs from an ordinary mall mainly in how it is organised. Third, Valor et al.'s (2022) strategies apply beyond clothing, but a guarantee of function, as at ReBuyke, is not covered by them. Fourth, the theatre view of van Marrewijk and Broos (2012) needs adjusting for reused goods, because backstage repair work can be shown as a sign of quality. The next chapter answers the research question and discusses the limits of these conclusions.

6 Conclusion

6.1 Answering the Research Question

The study asked:

How do the management and shop staff at ReTuna present reused products through discursive and material practices?

The answer is that they present reused products at two levels, in different ways. The management presents the place. Through a large, light and tidy hall, it gives reused goods the setting of an ordinary shopping center, and in its own communication it stresses the environmental benefit. It leaves the presentation of the products to the shops.

The shops present the products, and each does so differently. The IKEA second-hand shop presents used furniture as beautiful and stylish. Its posts tell the design history of products and place them in seasons and homes, its layout copies an ordinary IKEA store, and cleaning, waxing and washing are described as signs of care. ReBuyke presents used sports equipment as functional and safe to buy. It services and repairs the goods in view of customers, and it offers a guarantee and a right of return.

What the shops say and what they do mostly match. The clearest gap lies between the levels: the management says that second-hand goods should not be seen as cheap, while the shops, which set their own prices, use discounts, and the mall itself runs clearance weeks.

6.2 Contributions

The study makes three contributions. First, it shows that in a mall of second-hand shops, the presentation of reused goods is divided between the mall and the shops, with the environmental message at the mall level. Second, it shows that the strategies described by Valor et al. (2022) for clothing also appear for furniture and sports equipment, but that a guarantee of function, as at ReBuyke, is not covered by them. Third, it suggests an adjustment to the theatre view of van Marrewijk and Broos (2012): for reused goods, the backstage work of repair can be shown to customers as a sign of quality, rather than hidden.

6.3 Practical Implications

The findings may be useful for people who run or plan places like ReTuna, though they come from a single case. They suggest that the shops in such a mall do not need to repeat the environmental message, since the mall already carries it, and can speak to other reasons for buying. They also suggest that a mall which wants reused goods to be seen as good quality, not cheap, may need to agree on this with the shops, since the shops set their own prices.

6.4 Limits of the Conclusions

The limits of the data are described in Section 3.5. For the conclusions, three points matter most. First, the study shows how reused products are presented, not how customers react to this presentation. Whether the ordinary look of the mall or ReBuyke's guarantee makes customers more willing to buy cannot be concluded from these data. Second, ReTuna is an atypical case, so the conclusions may not apply to a single second-hand shop or to a mall without a recycling centre next to it. Third, the two shops were chosen partly because their staff agreed to be interviewed, so other shops in the mall may present their goods differently.

6.5 Directions for Future Research

Three directions follow from the study. First, research with customers could test whether the presentation described here affects how they see reused goods, for example whether a guarantee lowers the sense of risk for used bicycles, as Ross et al. (2023) found for return policies. Second, studies of other malls of second-hand shops could show whether the same division between mall and shops appears elsewhere. Third, a longer observation, with photographs and film inside the shops, could follow how a shop such as ReBuyke changes its presentation over time, for example after a rebuild.

6.6 Concluding Remarks

ReTuna looks like an ordinary shopping center, and that is part of how it presents reused goods. Behind the ordinary look, the mall and its shops share the work of making used things attractive: the mall speaks for the environment, and the shops speak for style, function and price. This study suggests that making reused goods mainstream may depend less on one strong message than on many actors, each presenting the goods in the way that fits what they sell.

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Appendix

Appendix A: Interview Guide - Mall Management

Research title: *Circular Retail Environments and the Presentation of Reused Products: A Case Study of ReTuna Recycling Mall, Sweden*

Participant group: Mall Management

Estimated duration: 20-30 minutes

Language: English

Opening Question

1. Could you start by telling me a little about your role here and how long you have been working at the mall?

Main Questions

2. How would you describe the overall concept of this mall to someone who has never visited before?

I. *How do you explain the difference between this place and a regular second-hand shop?*

3. How do you design and manage the physical environment of the mall to make it feel welcoming and attractive to shoppers?

I. *What specific decisions have been made about layout, lighting, signage, or presentation?*

II. *How do you think the physical environment affects how consumers feel about the products here?*

4. How does the mall communicate its concept and values to consumers-both inside the mall and through channels like social media?

I. *What kinds of words or messages do you use to describe the products and the concept?*

II. *How do you think this communication shapes how consumers think about reused goods?*

5. In your experience, how do consumers respond when they visit this mall for the first time?

I. *Do you notice a difference between how first-time visitors and returning customers behave?*

II. *Have you seen changes in consumer perceptions over the years the mall has been open?*

6. What do you think are the biggest challenges in getting mainstream consumers to see reused and repaired products as valuable and desirable?

I. *What strategies have worked best for overcoming any resistance or negative perceptions?*

7. How do you work with the individual store owners within the mall to ensure a consistent experience for consumers?

I. Do stores have guidelines about how to present products or communicate with customers?

Closing Question

8. Is there anything about how this mall operates or how it engages consumers that you think is often overlooked or misunderstood?

Appendix B: Interview Guide-Store Employees

Research title: *Circular Retail Environments and the Presentation of Reused Products: A Case Study of ReTuna Recycling Mall, Sweden*

Participant group: Store Employees / Shop Owners

Estimated duration: 20–30 minutes

Language: English

Opening Question

1. Could you tell me a little about your shop here-what kinds of products you sell and how long you have been based in this mall?

Main Questions

2. How do you prepare and present products before putting them out on the shop floor?

I. *What kind of repair, cleaning, or refurbishment do you do before products are displayed?*
II. *How do you decide how to display and arrange products in your store?*

3. How do you talk to customers about the products in your store?

I. *Do you tell customers about the history or origin of a product?*
II. *How do you describe the quality or value of a reused or repaired item to a customer?*

4. How do customers typically react when they look at or handle the products in your store?

I. *Do you notice any hesitation or concerns about quality or hygiene?*
II. *What seems to make customers feel more comfortable or confident about buying a reused product?*

5. Do you notice a difference in how customers behave in your store here compared to how they might behave in a regular shop or a standard charity shop?

I. *Have any customers told you how this place feels different from other second-hand shopping experiences?*

6. What do you think makes a customer decide to buy a reused item from your store rather than walk away?

I. *Is it the price, the quality, the presentation, or something else?*

7. How does being part of this larger mall environment affect your store and how customers perceive your products?

I. *Do you think customers trust the products more because of the overall environment of the mall?*

Closing Question

8. From your daily experience working here, what do you think this place does differently that changes how people feel about secondhand shopping?

Thank you very much for your time. Your insights are very valuable for this research.

Appendix C: Consumer Qualitative Questionnaire

Research title: *Circular Retail Environments and the Presentation of Reused Products: A Case Study of ReTuna Recycling Mall, Sweden*

Consumer Questionnaire

About your visit

Q1. Is this your first visit here, or have you been before?

□ First visit

□ I have visited before-approximately how many times?

Q2. What did you buy today?

_____

_____

_____

Q3. How does shopping here feel different from shopping in a regular store or a normal secondhand shop? Please describe the difference.

_____

_____

_____

Q4. When you look at the products here, what do you think about their quality and value? What influences your impression?

_____

_____

_____

Q5. Has visiting this place changed the way you think about buying secondhand or reused things at all? Please explain.

_____

_____

_____

Q6. Is there anything about this place-the layout, the atmosphere, the way products are displayed, or the way staff talk about the products-that makes you more or less comfortable buying reused items?

_____

_____

_____

Q7. Would you recommend this place to someone who has never tried secondhand shopping before? Why or why not?

_____

_____

_____

Thank you very much for your participation. Your responses are greatly appreciated.